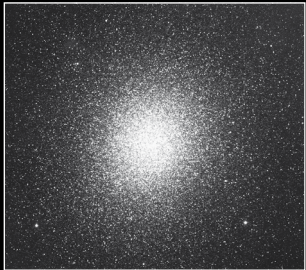




Alpha Centauri
By the horizon in this dawn sky, Alpha Centauri, just 4.3 light-years away, is often said to be our closest star after the Sun. An unseen companion, Proxima Centauri, is in fact slightly closer and truly the closest nighttime star.



Omega Centauri
The largest globular cluster in the Milky Way is Omega Centauri (NGC 5139). Just some of its 10 million or so stars are visible in this 13-ft (4-m) telescope image. To the naked eye or through binoculars, it appears as a fuzzy star.

SOUTHERN LATITUDES

Two bright stars, Spica (in Virgo) and Arcturus (Boötes), are centrally placed to the south. Arcturus is the lower and brighter of the two and the fourth-brightest star of all. Spica is almost overhead. To the northwest is Leo, which will soon be making way for the winter constellations. Ophiuchus, the serpent holder, is in the eastern sky. The serpent, which forms the constellation Serpens, is coiled around Ophiuchus—it is in two halves, one at either side of Ophiuchus. The head, Serpens Caput, is between Ophiuchus and Boötes; the tail, Serpens Cauda, is close to the eastern horizon.

Centaurus and Crux are high in the sky to the south. The two bright stars of Centaurus shine out, even against the starry path of the Milky Way. Alpha (α) Centauri is the brighter of the two and third-brightest of all. Within the centaur's body is Omega (ω) Centauri, the brightest globular cluster in all of Earth's sky. This month also offers the first good opportunity to look at Scorpius, a winter constellation that is now rising in the southeastern sky.

The Eta Aquarid meteor shower starts in late April but peaks in the first week of May, when about 35 meteors an hour can be seen. The meteors radiate from a point in Aquarius. They are visible in the hours before dawn as Earth plows into a stream of dust lost by Halley's Comet.



Boötes
The large figure of Boötes, the herdsman, raises his arm high in the sky. The top star of the kite shape marks his head. At the tail end of the kite is the red giant Arcturus, the brightest star north of the celestial equator.

